mlrc Multilingual Learning Research Center



MLRC Action Research Capstone

Suzhou Singapore International School

Designing Shared WIDA Support Tools to Strengthen Collaboration for Multilingual Learners

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Research Topic: Collaboration

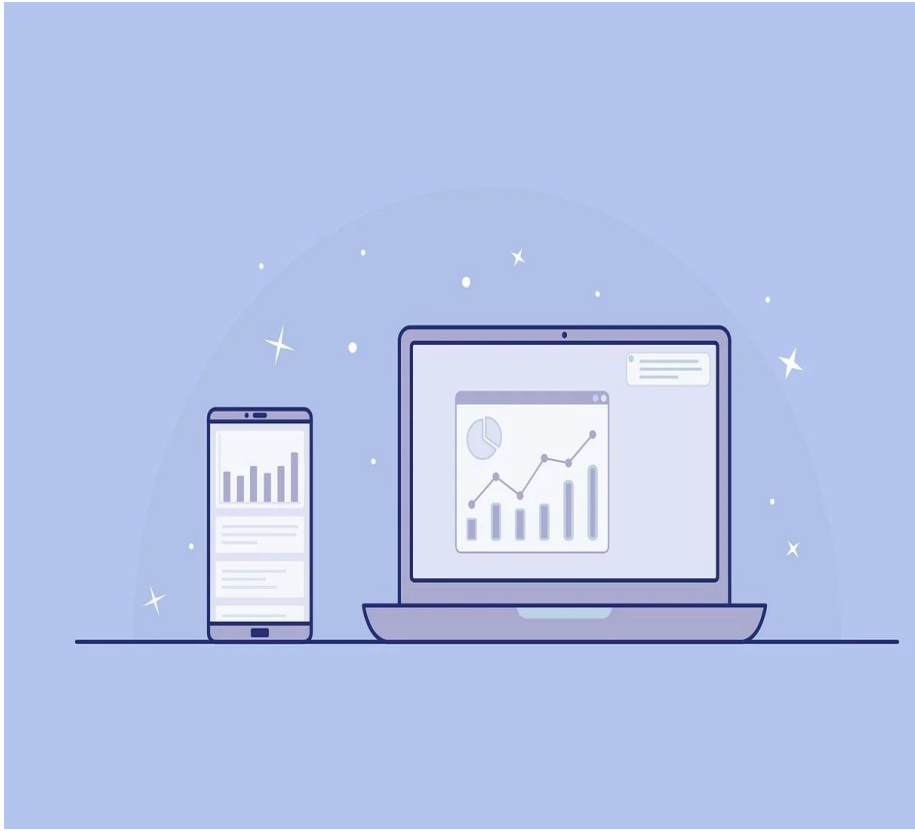
This project explores how teacher-designed WIDA support tools can strengthen shared understanding among:

- EAL teachers
- Classroom teachers
- School leaders
- Families



Research Question

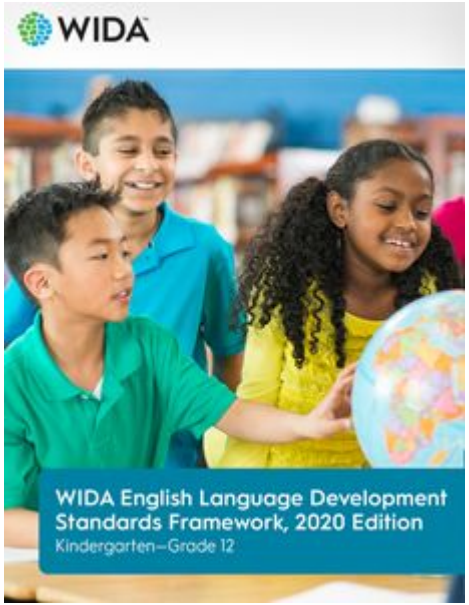
How can teacher-designed WIDA support tools strengthen shared understanding and collaboration among teachers, leaders, and families who support multilingual learners?



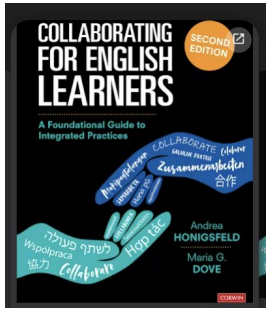
Problem of Practice

WIDA scores provide valuable information about multilingual learners' language development, but the meaning of those scores is not always clear to families, classroom teachers, or school leaders.

When WIDA data is difficult to understand, it becomes harder to build shared understanding and support students consistently across school and home.



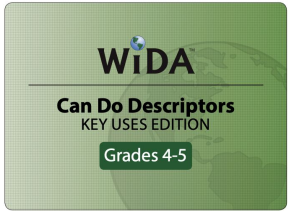
Literature Review



- **Collaboration matters:** Multilingual learners are better supported when EAL specialists, classroom teachers, leaders, and families share responsibility for language development.
  (Honigsfeld & Dove, 2019; WIDA, 2020)

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- **Families need accessible communication:** Family engagement is stronger when school information is clear, practical, and linguistically accessible.
  (WIDA Family & Community Engagement, n.d.)



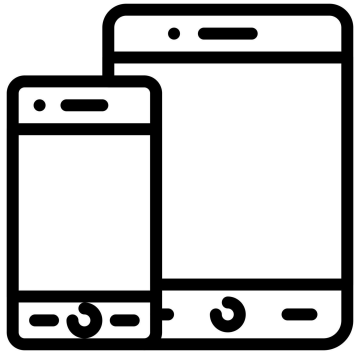
- **WIDA data becomes more useful when it is actionable:** Proficiency levels and Can Do Descriptors help translate scores into examples of what students can do and how adults can support next steps.
  (WIDA Can Do Descriptors, n.d.; WIDA, 2020)

Methodology

I designed and shared a **Multilingual Learner Family Guide App** to make WIDA levels easier to understand.

The app explains what students can do at different WIDA levels and provides home support suggestions. I collected early feedback through a short survey and informal stakeholder responses.





Methodology

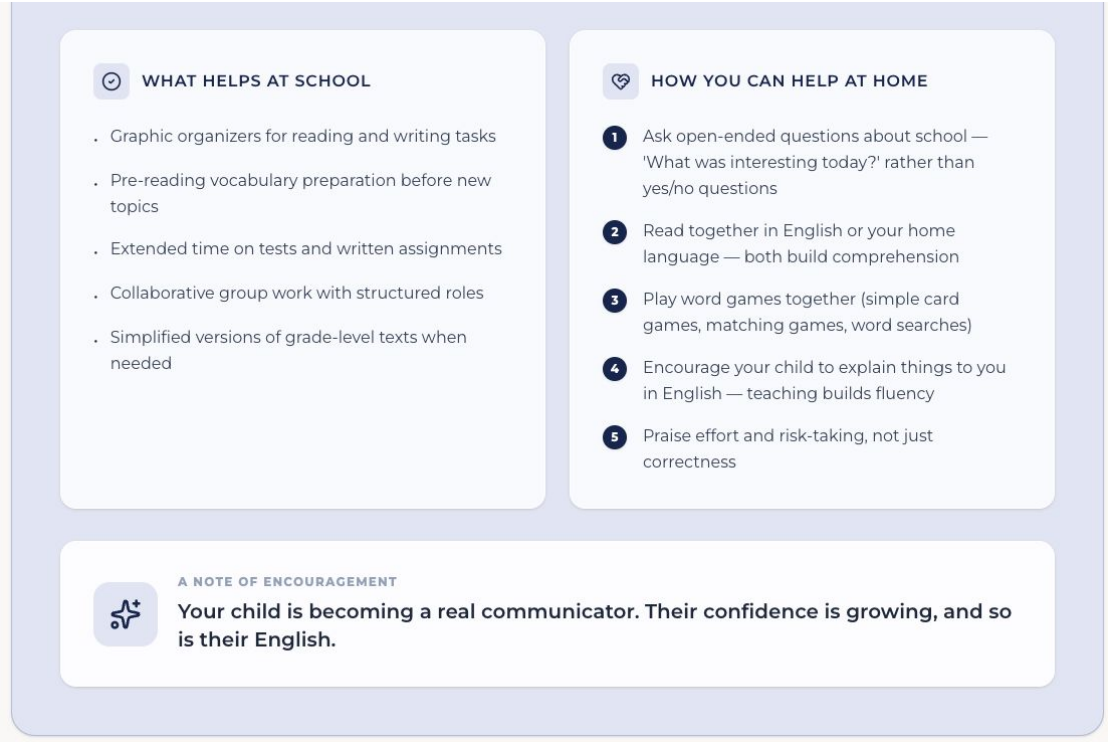
The app was designed as a family-friendly tool that explains WIDA levels, language domains, and home support strategies in accessible language.



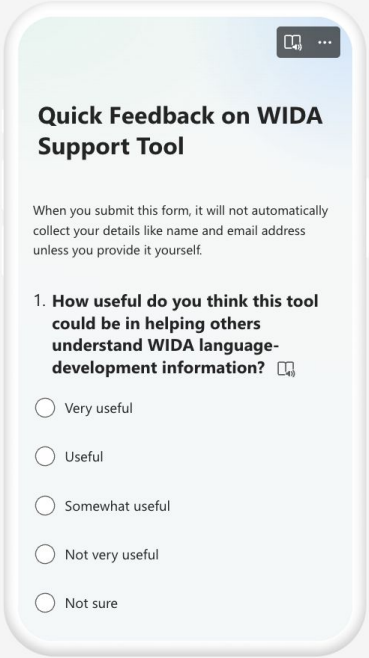


Methodology

The app was created to move beyond reporting WIDA scores by giving families clear examples of school supports, home strategies, and encouragement connected to language growth.

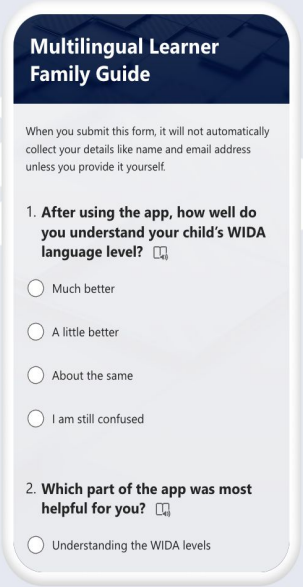


Stakeholder Feedback: The App Helped Make WIDA More Understandable and Actionable



- 6/6 early respondents rated the app **“Very useful.”**
- Respondents said the app clarified WIDA levels and student progress.
- Feedback suggested the app strengthened the connection between school and home support.
- Respondents saw value for parent meetings, homeroom teacher planning, and shared next steps.
- Suggested improvements included more translation options, a share button, optional teacher notes, and a parent question/resource space.

Family Feedback: Early Family Feedback Shows Increased Understanding



- 2 family responses have been received so far.
- Both families responded in Korean, showing the value of allowing home-language feedback.
- Both parents reported that the app helped them understand WIDA levels **“Much better.”**
- Both parents selected **“Understanding the WIDA levels”** as the most helpful part of the app.
- One parent suggested adding clearer guidance for how students can study at home.

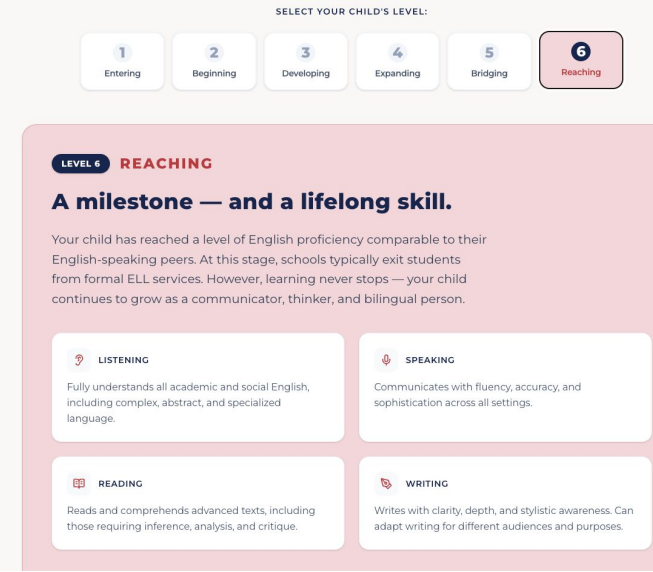
Discussion

The early findings suggest that WIDA support tools can act as bridges between assessment data and practical support.

The app did not replace collaboration. Instead, it created a clearer starting point for conversations among families, teachers, and school leaders.

The app helped bridge:

- **Data → Understanding**
- **EAL expertise → Classroom practice**
- **School language → Family access**



Discussion

Relevance for my school:
The app can support parent meetings, WIDA score communication, homeroom teacher planning, and shared language around student growth.

Relevance for other schools:
Other international schools may face similar challenges when explaining language proficiency data to multilingual families and classroom teachers.

Importance for the field:
Teacher-designed tools can help make language-development knowledge more accessible, practical, and collaborative.



Project Evolution



My original capstone idea focused on vocabulary instruction and gathering strategies from teachers. As the year progressed, I noticed a deeper problem of practice: WIDA data was being used, but the meaning of that data was not always clear to families, classroom teachers, or school leaders.

This shifted my project from collecting vocabulary strategies to designing shared WIDA support tools. The focus became more specific: how can tools help different stakeholders understand multilingual learner development and respond more effectively?

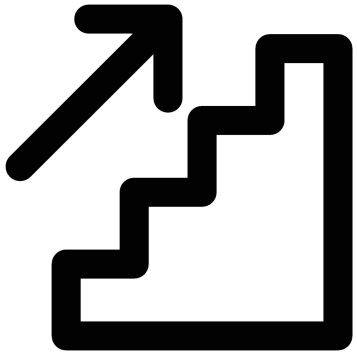
Limitations

- Survey data represents early feedback, not a full evaluation of long-term impact.
- Parent responses are still limited because the survey was sent near the end of the project timeline.
- More feedback is needed after updated WIDA results are shared with families.



Next steps

- Add more translation options
- Add clearer home-study guidance by WIDA level
- Add a parent question/resource space
- Add easier sharing features
- Explore how homeroom teachers might use the tool during planning



Conclusion: From Scores to Shared Understanding



This project helped me see that WIDA data becomes more powerful when it is easier for others to understand and use.

By turning language-development information into a clear, accessible tool, EAL teachers can support stronger collaboration with families, classroom teachers, and school leaders.

Explore the app by clicking this link or scanning the QR Code!
https://www.mymultilingualfamily.com/

This educator-created tool references and adapts concepts from the WIDA English Language Development Standards Framework.*This tool is not affiliated with, reviewed by, sponsored by, or endorsed by WIDA.*

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Feel free to contact me with any questions, comments or feedback.

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